
ΣΚΗΠΤΟΥΧΟΙ ΒΑΣΙΛΕΙΣ: AN ARGUMENT FOR DIVINE KINGSHIP IN EARLY GREECE

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ΣΚΗΠΤΟΥΧΟΙ ΒΑΣΙΛΕΙΣ: AN ARGUMENT FOR DIVINE KINGSHIP IN EARLY GREECE

ROBERT MONDI

The earliest known religion is a
belief in the divinity of kings.

A. M. Hocart

THE SOCIAL ROLE of the Homeric *basileús* is to a large extent a religious one. His responsibility as chief sacrificer and preserver of ritual custom is at least as important as his functioning as commander-in-chief. Such a conception of royal authority is not peculiar to Greece, and may well be an Indo-European inheritance:

Le *rex* indo-européen est beaucoup plus religieux que politique. Sa mission n'est pas de commander, d'exercer un pouvoir, mais de fixer des règles, de déterminer ce qui est, au sens propre, "droit."¹

The king determines and upholds this "droit" (Greek *thémis*, Indic *dharma*, etc.) through divine sanction, and much of the emblemism and ritual of his office points to the close association between king and god.

The ethnographic studies of Sir James Frazer, A. M. Hocart and others have supplied numerous examples world-wide in which this association is so close as to be viewed as an identity. (In Hocart's formulation,² king = god.) Unfortunately, the attempts of these men (and here must also be included A. B. Cook's study of Zeus) to apply these observations to a search for the origins of the social institutions of antiquity are sometimes vitiated by a misleading conflation of evidence and a superficial treatment of the texts. Still, it is likely that a belief in divine kingship was current in the Mediterranean basin and the Near East during the bronze age, among both Indo-European and non-Indo-European peoples. The divinity of the Egyptian pharaohs is certain, and arguments have been made for some form of sacral kingship in Mesopotamia, Crete, among the Hittites, and in India.³ The possibility that the Greeks of this period held a similar belief, be it through inheritance or assimilation,⁴ is one which deserves more careful and elaborate consideration.

Many of the arguments for divine kingship in Greece brought forth by the members of the Myth and Ritual school, the heirs to the Golden Bough, are without substance and have been deservedly refuted.⁵ But some have withstood attack. One passage frequently cited as evidence for a “primitive” conception of the king as a magico-religious figure who somehow controls the weather and is accountable for the fertility and fecundity of the realm is the description of the ideal king in the *Odyssey* (19.109-114):⁶

ὥς τέ τευ ἡ βασιλῆος ἀμύμονος, ὃς τε θεοῦδης
 ἀνδράσιν ἐν πολλοῖσι καὶ ἰφθίμοισιν ἀνάσσω
 εὐδικίας ἀνέχῃσι, φέρῃσι δὲ γαῖα μέλαινα
 πυροῦς καὶ κριθάς, βρίθῃσι δὲ δένδρεα καρπῶ,
 τίκτη δ' ἔμπεδα μῆλα, θάλασσα δὲ παρέχῃ ἰχθῦς
 ἕξ εὐηγεσίης, ἀρετῶσι δὲ λαοὶ ὑπ' αὐτοῦ.

Like [the fame] of a blameless and reverent king, who upholds justice ruling over many strong men; and because of his good leadership the dark earth bears wheat and barley, the trees are laden with fruit, the flocks multiply unceasingly, the sea abounds in fish, and the people prosper under him.

We find a parallel theme in the *Works and Days* (232ff.): Under a king who exercises *dīkē* the earth is fruitful, while the king who displays *húbris* brings λιμός and λοιμός upon his people.⁷ This connection between kingship and fertility, which is the backbone of the Myth and Ritual theory, appears in other early Indo-European texts. The following prayer was recited daily for the Hittite king Mursilis:

To the king and queen, the princes and the land of Hatti, grant life, health, strength, long years, and enduring joy. Grant everlasting fertility to their crops, vines, fruit trees, cattle, sheep, goats, pigs, mules, and asses, together with the beasts of the fields, and to their people. Let them flourish! Let the winds of prosperity pass over! Let the land of Hatti thrive and prosper.⁸

The *Mahābhārata* provides a description of life under a just king which is strongly reminiscent of the Hesiodic passage:

Indra, seeing that all the kṣatriya sovereigns ruled their kingdoms very virtuously, poured down vivifying showers of rain

at the proper time and proper place and protected all creatures.⁹

In each case, the weather god is thought to grant rain and fertility through the person of the king. We need not go so far as to propose, as does Cook, “a king of the old magical sort . . . who controlled the weather for his people . . . and passed as a human Zeus,”¹⁰ but rather an exceptional, supra-human figure, believed to possess a certain divine power or efficacy, and treated by the rest of his society with a reverence and devotion otherwise reserved for the celestial deities. That is, not *deus*, but *numen*.¹¹

Émile Benveniste has observed that the language describing the interaction between man and his king in the Homeric poems is often the same as that expressing the relationship between man and god. The terms *gêras*, which connotes an honor or prerogative based on some extraordinary status (cf. the expressions γέρας θανόντων, γέρας γερόντων) is most frequently used of the honor which is accorded to the gods or to the *basileis*:¹² it signifies both the material offerings given to the Olympians (i.e., the burnt sacrifice, *Il.* 4.49, 24.70, *h.Merc.* 122), and also that prime portion of the spoils of war which the Achaeans reserve for the *basileis* (particularly Agamemnon) as a sort of first offering. Alcinous receives similar honor from his people (*Od.* 7.10-11):

Ἄλκινόφ δ' αὐτὴν γέρας ἔξελον, οὐνεκα πᾶσι
Φαίηκεσσιν ἄνασσε, θεοῦ δ' ὧς δῆμος ἄκουεν.

They selected her [Arete] as a *gêras* for Alcinous, because he ruled over all of the Phaeaceans, and the people obeyed him as they would a god.

In the *Theogony* *gêras* designates the particular sphere of influence that each god receives in the departmentalization of divine rule (393, 427). The word occurs in a similar sense at *Il.* 20.182: if Aeneas were to succeed to the throne of Priam, he would receive the *gêras* of kingship as well as the royal *têmenos*.¹³

Similar in semantic distribution is the verb *kraínein*.¹⁴ Nestor's entreaty of Agamemnon to relent in his anger includes the following passage (*Il.* 9.96-102):

Ἀτρεΐδῃ κύδιστε, ἄναξ ἀνδρῶν Ἀγάμεμνον,
ἐν σοὶ μὲν λήξω, σέο δ' ἄρξομαι, οὐνεκα πολλῶν
λαῶν ἐσσι ἄναξ καὶ τοι Ζεὺς ἐγγυάλιξε

σκῆπτρόν τ' ἡδὲ θέμιστας, ἵνα σφίσι βουλευῆσθα.
 τῷ σε χρή πέρι μὲν φάσθαι ἔπος ἡδ' ἐπακοῦσαι,
 κρηῆναι δὲ καὶ ἄλλω, ὅτ' ἂν τινα θυμὸς ἀνώγη
 εἰπεῖν εἰς ἀγαθόν· σέο δ' ἔξεται ὅττι κεν ἄρχῃ.

Most glorious son of Atreus, Agamemnon, Lord of men, I will begin and end with you, since you are lord over many people and Zeus has placed in your hands the *skêptron* and *thémistes*, so that you might counsel on their behalf. Therefore it behooves you above all to speak out and to listen, and to grant this also to another, whenever a man's spirit moves him to speak for the common good. Every undertaking depends on you.

The first two lines are immediately recognizable as an honorific formulation very similar to the type commonly found in the Homeric hymns.¹⁵ The verb designating Agamemnon's favorable response to this "prayer" is κρηῆναι. The most frequent Homeric use of this verb is in the phrase (ἐπι)κρηῆναι ἐέλδωρ, almost always in the context of a prayer (hence likely to be an archaic expression preserving the oldest meaning of the verb), and always of a favorable divine response to that prayer.¹⁶ In post-Homeric Greek *kraínein* loses its marked significance and often means simply "rule," but the derivation of the verb preserves its original connection with divine approval: the underlying root is that found in the noun *kára*,¹⁷ and it is above all the consent of Zeus that is indicated by a nod of the head (*h. Ven.* 222):

τῇ δὲ Ζεὺς ἐπένευσε καὶ ἐκρήνηεν ἐέλδωρ.

Zeus nodded to her and granted her wish.

The Achaeans honor their king with a *géras* (perhaps we should say appease him, judging from the reaction of the *basileús* at becoming *agérastos*), and his favorable reaction in return is *kraínein*. So far all is synonymous with the reciprocal interaction between men and gods. But what of the negative side of this reciprocity? Does the expression of royal displeasure in any way parallel or derive from that of divine retribution?

* * *

There is a widespread consensus that it is normal procedure in the Homeric *agora* for each speaker to receive the *skêptron* from the *kêrux* and

to hold it as he addresses those assembled. Frederick Combellack made a convincing case against the validity of this notion over 30 years ago, but it has tenaciously persisted.¹⁸ It is supported directly by only two passages in Homer (*Il.* 23.567-568, *Od.* 2.37-38); from these it has been inferred that the *kêrux* hands the *skêptron* to *anyone* who addresses the *agora*. However, those passages which introduce formal speeches are among the most stereotypical in Homeric diction. If the transferring of the *skêptron* from herald to speaker were in fact an integral prelude to public address, it would be odd that, out of all such speeches reported in the poems, this detail should be mentioned only twice.

Combellack's conclusion, however, that the *skêptron* is held by a speaker only when "there is something particularly solemn about his words"¹⁹ does not go far enough. We must recognize that the *skêptron* is representative not so much of the political clout of the *basileús* as of the divine basis of his authority. This much is clear from the belief that it has descended from Olympus (*Il.* 2.101-108; 205-206; 9.98-99): Agamemnon's *skêptron* was made by Hephaestus for Zeus himself, and was subsequently delivered by Hermes to its first human recipient, Pelops.²⁰ It is a concrete entity for Homer, often linked with the notion of *thémis* (*Il.* 2.205-206):

εἰς βασιλεύς, ὃ δῶκε Κρόνου πάϊς ἀγκυλομήτεω
σκήπτρόν τ' ἠδὲ θέμιστας, ἵνα σφίσι βουλεύησι.

[Let there be] one *basileús*, to whom the son of devious Kronos has given the *skêptron* and *thémistes*, so that he might counsel on behalf of his people.

Taken together, *skêptron* and *thémis* represent the visible and the abstract expressions of the divine sanction on which the king bases his authority.²¹

The symbolic importance of the *skêptron* is made even more explicit in Diomedes' chiding of Agamemnon (*Il.* 9.38-39):

σκήπτρῳ μὲν τοι δῶκε τετιμῆσθαι περὶ πάντων,
ἀλκὴν δ' οὐ τοι δῶκεν, ὃ τε κράτος ἐστὶ μέγιστον.

He [Zeus] granted that with the *skêptron* you be honored above all men, but he did not give you courage, which is the greatest strength of all.

We see that it is *only* the backing of Zeus, as represented by the *skêptron*, which sets the *basileús* apart from the rest of the nobility, not any in-

herent personal excellence. The *skêptron* has a certain autonomy in itself: in a real sense, it does not symbolize the kingship, but it *is* the kingship.²² It is a critical adjunct to the king's appearance, and he yields it only in certain well-defined situations: to the *kêrux*, when he is functioning as proxy for the king (e.g., *Il.* 7.277); for the dispensation of *dikê*, a function which seems to have been carried out by a body of men separate from the king (cf. *Il.* 1.238, 18.505); and finally to a speaker, *only* when the authority of the king himself is to be placed in the speaker's words, as when Odysseus borrows the *skêptron* of Agamemnon to recall the retreating Achaeans (*Il.* 2.185-186).²³

We can refine this yet one step further and say that the *skêptron* is symbolic of one particular aspect of the king's authority, his ability to exercise his will by threatening (at times, only implicitly) the consequences of royal retribution. In virtually every instance where a speaker in the assembly is holding the *skêptron*, his words are in some way hostile or threatening: Odysseus chastising the fleeing Achaeans (*Il.* 2.186ff.), Telemachus lashing out at the Ithacans (*Od.* 2.37ff.), Menelaus rebuking Antilochus (*Il.* 23.567-569), Achilles cursing Agamemnon (*Il.* 1.234), and Odysseus attempting to intimidate the Trojans into returning Helen (*Il.* 3.210ff.).

The *skêptron* is used to lend weight to the king's threats, particularly in those situations where he cannot really back up those threats with any direct action, but must rely on this reminder of the divine source of his authority. The last example cited above is indicative of how this is accomplished. In his use of the *skêptron* Odysseus actually departs from normal practice (*Il.* 3.218-219):

σκήπτρον δ' οὐτ' ὀπίσω οὔτε προπρηνὲς ἐνώμα,
ἀλλ' ἄστεμφές ἔχεσκεν, αἰδρεῖ φῶτι ἔοικώς.

He did not ply the *skêptron* in front or behind, but he held it stationary, as would an ignorant man.

That is to say, rather than hold it stationary, as Odysseus does, a speaker would normally, under these circumstances, ply it back and forth in a minatory fashion, thereby rendering the retributive power implicit in it more palpable to the audience.

Even more graphic is the occasional use of the *skêptron* itself as the instrument of that retribution. When Odysseus borrows Agamemnon's *skêptron* to round up the Achaeans, he persuades the other *basileis* with

ἀγανοῖς ἐπέεσσιν (*Il.* 2.188-189) but the common soldiers get a different treatment (*Il.* 2.198-199):

δν δ' αὖ δῆμου τ' ἄνδρα ἴδοι βοόωντά τ' ἐφεύροι,
τὸν σκήπτρῳ ἐλάσασκεν ὁμοκλήσασκέ τε μύθῳ.

But whenever he came upon a man of the *dēmos* shouting, he struck him with the *skēptron* and reproached him.

Following this, he publicly humiliates Thersites for his insubordination, and again the *skēptron* is put to more than symbolic use (*Il.* 2.265-266):

ὥς ἄρ' ἔφη, σκήπτρῳ δὲ μετάφρενον ἡδὲ καὶ ὤμῳ
πλῆξεν· ὁ δ' ἰδνώθη, θαλερὸν δέ οἱ ἔκπεσε δάκρυ.

Speaking thus, he struck him on the back and shoulders, and Thersites bent over double and shed a warm tear.

Nor is this violence specific to Odysseus. There are two instances in the *Iliad* of a noun *skēpánion*, apparently an alternate formation for *skēptron*. at *Il.* 13.59-60 Poseidon strikes the vacillating Aeantes with it to urge them back into battle, and at 24.247-248 Priam punctuates a condemnatory speech to a few of his more cowardly sons in a similar manner.²⁴

To proceed beyond this point we must examine the derivational connection between *skēptron* and the related words *sképtein* and *skēptós*. The semantic link is commonly supposed to be through the middle *sképtesthai*, “lean on.”²⁵ But it is only in the *Odyssey* and in later literature that the word *skēptron* becomes so vulgarized as to be commonly used of a walking-stick.²⁶ And in any event, this still leaves unexplained the connection with the active *sképtein* and with *skēptós*.

I propose to begin rather with the noun *skēptós*. The first attestation of this word is post-Homeric (as is that of the verb *sképtein*), but the Homeric adjective *skēptoûkhos* presupposes a productive stem *skēpt-*. In the *Persae*, the ghost of Darius asks Atossa how the city met its fate (715):

τίνι τρόπῳ; λοιμοῦ τις ἦλθε σκηπτὸς ἢ στάσις πόλει;

By what means? Did the onset of plague strike the city, or civil strife?

Of the two possibilities, *skēptós* represents the destruction sent from without, while *stásis* is that which the citizens bring upon themselves. Sophocles uses the word in reference to a sudden dust-storm (*Ant.* 417-419):

καὶ τότε' εξαίφνης χθονὸς
 τυφῶς αἰείρας σκηπτόν, οὐράνιον ἄχος,
 πίμπλησι πεδίον.

And then suddenly a storm of dust — heaven-sent grief —
 reared its force and filled the plain.

Here the source of the *skēptós* is even more explicit: it is an οὐράνιον ἄχος. Finally, we learn from Aristotle (*De Mundo* 395a28) that a *skēptós* is a certain type of thunderbolt, the “heavenly grief” *par excellence*. In each of these instances, the phenomenon referred to as a *skēptós* — λοιμός, οὐράνιον ἄχος, κεραυνός — is an ill which was felt to be visited upon humanity by an outside natural force.

And what is, ultimately, the source of such natural catastrophe? The use of the verb *sképtein* leaves little doubt. Consider the divine retaliation for Paris’ abuse of *xenía*: (Aesch. *Ag.* 362-366).²⁷

Δία τοι ξένιον μέγαν αἰδοῦμαι
 τὸν τάδε πράξαντ', ἐπ' Ἀλεξάνδρῳ
 τείνοντα πάλαι τόξον, ὅπως ἂν
 μήτε πρὸ καιροῦ μήθ' ὑπὲρ ἄστρον
 βέλος ἡλίθιον σκήψειεν.

I stand in great awe of Zeus *Xenios* who has brought these things to pass — long ago straining his bow toward Alexander so that the shaft would not descend in vain either short of the mark or beyond the stars.

Elsewhere in 5th-century literature *sképtein* and its compounds refer to the descent of the anger of the deified Talthybius (Hdt. 7.134.1), that of the *orgaí* of Aphrodite (Eur. *Hipp.* 438), the incidence of lightning (Hdt. 7.10.e), and of the plague (Soph. *OT* 27-28, Thuc. 2.49).

The implication of these passages is clear: from the time of their first attestations, *skēptós* and *sképtein* are commonly used of the descent of divine wrath, generally manifested by an upheaval in nature. What now has this to do with the king’s *skēptron*? In the first Pythian ode Pindar boasts that even the might of Zeus can be placated with poetry (*P.* 1.5-6):

καὶ τὸν αἰχματὰν κεραυνὸν σβεννύεις
 αἰενάου πυρός. εὔδει δ' ἀνὰ σκά-
 πτῳ Διὸς αἰετός.

You quench even the warrior thunderbolt of unceasing fire;
and Zeus' eagle sleeps on his *skêptron*.

Here is the semantic connection that we are seeking. The fact that the power of Zeus is temporarily at rest is expressed on two symbolic levels: his thunderbolt (i.e., the *skêptós*), the natural manifestation of his might, is extinguished; secondly, his *skêptron*, the concrete symbol of that power, is also at rest.²⁸

The *basileús* cannot, of course, hurl the thunderbolt, but he does wield an object which represents it and adds the weight of divine wrath to royal displeasure. One need only consider what Achilles does with the *skêptron* at the end of his speech in Book 1 to see the connection (*Il.* 1.245):

ὥς φάτο Πηλεΐδης, ποτὶ δὲ σκῆπτρον βάλε γαίῃ.

Thus spoke the son of Peleus, and he hurled the *skêptron* to the ground.

Vernant interprets this as “un rejet de l'autorité royale,”²⁹ but we must take into account also the similar action of Telemachus before the Ithacan nobles (*Od.* 2.80):

ὥς φάτο χωόμενος, ποτὶ δὲ σκῆπτρον βάλε γαίῃ.

Thus he spoke in anger, and hurled the *skêptron* to the ground.

By throwing it to the ground he is not rejecting the authority vested in the *skêptron* (which presumably is his own), but rather he is emphatically affirming it. The *skêptron* is hurled to earth as a demonstration of royal anger, just as the *skêptós*, the divine natural force which it represents, would have been.³⁰

* * *

What can we conclude? We have seen that the *skêptron*, an attribute so inextricably associated with the king that it itself ultimately comes to be an abstract designation for kingship,³¹ represents the divine source of the king's authority and is conspicuously manipulated during expressions of royal anger and intimidation. If the name for this object is derived from a group of words whose most common use is to express the natural manifestation of divine wrath, it is not at all unreasonable to suppose that we have embodied in the Homeric *skêptron* a dimming memory of an

archaic conception of kingship as endowed with a superhuman (divine, if you will) ability to influence the natural elements, through the threatened use of which the king exercised his will.

Recall the words of Nestor to Agamemnon (*Il.* 9.38):

σκήπτρῳ μὲν τοι δῶκε τετιμῆσθαι περὶ πάντων.

He [Zeus] granted that with the *skêptron* you be honored above all men.

The *basileús* receives *tímé* because of his *skêptron*; that is, because of his ability to punish anyone who withholds it.³² The *Iliad* in fact provides us with an example of just such a challenge to the king. Why does Thersites receive no support from the other Achaeans? They were certainly elated at the prospect of returning home and must share his deep disappointment; but far from supporting or sympathizing with him, they mock him and praise Odysseus for humiliating him. This is the only example of direct disobedience to Agamemnon – even Achilles, when the shouting and cursing is over, yields to him in giving up Briseis. What Thersites has done is tantamount to sacrilege: by proposing that they go home and let Agamemnon amass his own booty, he is essentially proposing that they deprive the king of his *géras*, and the penalty for such an act is functionally the same as if he were depriving Zeus of his honor – he is struck down by a blow of the *skêptron*.

We can say, then, that the Iliadic tradition knows of a period when kings were regarded as endowed with some degree of divinity, but recalls it only dimly, and from a great distance. It stands at a turning point in the evolution of Greek social structure. The *Odyssey* already shows a tendency toward the secularization and vulgarizing of many of the terms with which we have been here concerned: *kráinein* is becoming an unmarked word for “rule” (8.391); *géras* is used once of a gift to a slave (20.297); *ánax* often means merely “head of the household”; and the *skêptron* itself serves as a beggar’s cane. But the abuse of the royal family and household by the suitors shows perhaps better than anything else that the divine sanction on which the *basileús* had implicitly based his authority was no longer salient, and had to be reinforced with physical power of a more human kind: the *skêptron* had to give place after all to *alké*, and Hesiod’s golden kings devolved into the warriors of the bronze age.³³

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NOTES

- ¹ É. Benveniste, *Le vocabulaire des institutions indo-européennes* (Paris 1969) II 15. For the Roman *rex* cf. K. Latte, *Römische Religionsgeschichte* (München 1960) 195; J. Gonda, "The Sacred Character of Ancient Indian Kingship," in *La regalità sacra, Studies in the History of Religions* 4 (Leiden 1959) 179-180; Benveniste II 9ff. For the Indic *rāja*, cf. Gonda 174. For the Hittite kings, cf. O. Gurney, "Hittite Kingship," in *Myth, Ritual and Kingship*, ed. S. H. Hooke (Oxford 1958) 114; I. Engnell, *Studies in Divine Kingship in the Ancient Near East* (Oxford 1967) 62.
- ² *Kings and Councillors* (Cairo 1936) 74.
- ³ Crete: cf. A. Furumark, "Was There a Sacral Kingship in Minoan Crete?" in *La regalità sacra* 369-370; E. O. James, *Myth and Ritual in the Ancient Near East* (London 1958) 101. India: J. Gonda, "Ancient Indian Kingship from the Religious Point of View," *Numen* 3 (1956) 36f.; M. Monier-Williams, *Religious Thought and Life in India* (London 1883) 259; J. Puhvel, "Greek *ANAX*," *KZ* 73 (1956) 209. *The Hittites*: Gurney (above, note 1) 115ff.; Engnell (above, note 1) 58.
- ⁴ The many similarities in religious and mythological thought between Greece and Mesopotamia (e.g., the creation myth, the kingship in heaven, the flood, as well as many thematic parallels between *Gilgamesh* and the Greek epics) should deter us from precluding the possibility that the Greeks might also have been influenced by Near Eastern social institutions. See C. Scott Littleton, "Is the 'Kingship in Heaven' Theme Indo-European?" in *Indo-European and Indo-Europeans*, edd. G. Cardona, H. M. Hoernigswald and A. Senn (Philadelphia 1970) 383-404; J. Puhvel, "Helladic Kingship and the Gods," in *Minoica, Festschrift Johannes Sundwall*, ed. E. Grumach (Berlin 1958) 328.
- ⁵ E.g., H. J. Rose, "The Evidence for Divine Kingship in Greece," in *La regalità sacra* (above, note 1) 371-378; A. N. Marlow, "Myth and Ritual in Early Greece," *Bulletin of the John Rylands Library* 43 (1960-61) 373-402; J. Fontenrose, *The Ritual Theory of Myth* (Berkeley 1971) 8.
- ⁶ When Rose (above, note 5) 373 attempts to explain this passage by saying that "the poet insists on the piety and justice of the king, and it is a commonplace that the gods reward such conduct," he is doing precisely what "the poet" is doing when he attributes the fertility to the δίκη of the king -- trying to account for an archaism in terms of 8th-century religious thought.
- ⁷ These descriptions of life under a just king sound much like that of the Hesiodic golden age, and J.-P. Vernant (*Mythe et pensée chez les Grecs* [Paris 1974] I 20ff., 62) in fact discusses the men of the race of gold in terms of idealized kingship ("les hommes d'or, ces Royaux, incarnation de la justice du Souverain"). At the end of the golden age they become *daimones* (*Works and Days* 122) who bestow bounty and are accorded a γέρας βασιλῆϊον (126). Cf. M. L. West, *Hesiod, Works and Days* (Oxford 1978) 183; Vernant 141f., Benveniste (above, note 1) II 27.
- ⁸ Trans. H. Otten, *Orientalische Literaturzeitung* 51 (1956) coll. 102ff.
- ⁹ *Mbh.* 1.64.16. Cited and discussed by Gonda (above, note 3) 42-43.
- ¹⁰ *Zeus, A Study in Ancient Religion* (Cambridge 1914-1940) II 1074; cf. also I 12; 79, II 1122; 1159.
- ¹¹ See L. Gernet, *Anthropologie de la Grèce antique* (Paris 1968) 426ff.; Vernant (above, note 7) I 22; M. Detienne, *Les maîtres de vérité dans la Grèce archaïque* (Paris 1967) 41f. For reflexes of divine kingship in Greek mythology, see P. Walcot's treatment of Heracles (*SMEA* 2 [1967]

53-62) and L. Edmunds' discussion of the Oedipus myth (*Comparative Civilizations Bulletin*, 8.3 [1979] 1-12).

¹² Benveniste II 43-49.

¹³ In the Homeric tradition, *témenos* is, like *gérās*, generally a privilege of god and king: cf. *Od.* 8.363; *Il.* 2.696, 6.194, 18.550. It is commonly linked with βῶμος, e.g., *Il.* 8.48, etc. Cf. H. van Effenterre, "Téménos," *REG* 80 (1967) 22.

¹⁴ Benveniste II 35ff.

¹⁵ Cf. *Hymn* 21.3-4:

σὲ δ' αἰδὼς ἔχων φόρμιγγα λίγειαν
ἡδυεπὴς πρῶτόν τε καὶ ὕστατον αἰὲν αἶδει.

The sweet-voiced bard with his clear-sounding *phórmnix* always sings of
you first and last.

and also *hymn* 18.10-11:

καὶ σὺ μὲν οὕτω χαῖρε Διὸς καὶ Μαιάδος υἱέ·
σεῦ δ' ἐγὼ ἀρξάμενος μεταβήσομαι ἄλλον ἐς ὕμνον.

So farewell, son of Zeus and Maia; beginning with you I will go on to the
rest of my song.

Puhvel (above, note 3) 204 interprets the title *ánax* as "an archaic epithet which was originally characteristic of the gods," with the meaning "divine or divinely sanctioned protector." See also L. R. Palmer, *The Interpretation of Mycenaean Greek Texts* (Oxford 1963) 83f.

¹⁶ The exact expression κῆνον ἔπος occurs in a prayer to Zeus at *Od.* 20.115:

κῆνον νῦν καὶ ἐμοὶ δειλῇ ἔπος, ὅττι κεν εἴπω.

Grant me in my misery this prayer that I make.

¹⁷ Benveniste II 42. The Latin cognate of the Greek *neúein* gives the semantically equivalent *nu-men*.

¹⁸ "Speakers and Scepters in Homer," *CJ* 43 (1948) 209-217. The idea can still be found in Vernant (above, note 7) I 135; West, *Hesiod, Theogony* (Oxford 1966) 163; Benveniste II 30.

¹⁹ Combellack (above, note 18) 210.

²⁰ For the divine source of the *skēptron*, cf. also Aesch. *PV* 170, *Pers.* 762ff., *Soph. Philoc.* 140. The scepter had a similar divine symbolic value in Egypt and Mesopotamia, and its transference to the new king was a central part of the coronation ritual. See H. Frankfort, *Kingship and the Gods* (Chicago 1948) 87, 247.

²¹ Cf. C. Gatti, "Uso dello scettro presso i gechi visto attraverso le opere omerico-esiodee; lo scettro presso egiziani e babilonesi," *Acme* 2 (1949) 24. The religious symbolism of the *skēptron* is also evident from its association with the *arētér* Chryses (*Il.* 1.14-15), Teiresias (*Od.* 11.91), Nestor, when he is about to pray to Athene (*Od.* 3.412), and also its use in the swearing of oaths (*Il.* 7.412, 1.234, 10.321; *h.Merc.* 460-461). Cf. also Aesch. *Agamemnon* 1265. For the connection between *skēptron* and *thémis*, cf. *Od.* 11.569, *Il.* 9.99, and Pind. *O.* 1.12-13.

- ²² There is a remarkably close parallel to the descent of the **skēptron** (and the kingship) from the gods in the following Babylonian text, cited by Frankfort (above, note 20) 237-238:

They (the gods) had not yet set up a king for the beclouded people
No headband and crown had (yet) been fastened . . .
No scepter had (yet) been studded with lapis lazuli . . .

Scepter, crown, headband and staff
Were (still) placed before Anu in heaven
So that there was no counseling of its (i.e., kingship's) people
(Then) kingship descended from heaven.

The sceptered king will counsel his people. The language in the Greek is very similar (*Il.* 9.98-99):

λαῶν ἔσσι ἀναξ καὶ τοι Ζεὺς ἐγγυάλιξε
σκήπτρόν τ' ἥδ' ἐθέμιστας, ἵνα σφίσι βουλευήσῃα.

You are lord over many people and Zeus has placed in your hands the **skēptron** and *thémistes*, so that you might counsel on their behalf.

- ²³ For further evidence that the **skēptron** is a normal part of the king's raiment, note the "arming scene" of Agamemnon (*Il.* 2.41ff.), the **basileús** portrayed on the shield of Achilles (18.556-557), the use of the verb **phoreîn** (as opposed to **phéreîn**) to describe Agamemnon's carrying it (2.107), and the restriction of the epithet **skēptoukhos** to kings. It is not clear whether the other Greek **basileîs** at Troy have their own **skēptra**; Agamemnon is the only figure explicitly said to possess one. It may be that, just as there was felt to be a need for a single **basileús** in the microcosmic Greek society at Troy (cf. *Il.* 2.204-205), so too the Achaeans were subject to just one **skēptron**.
- ²⁴ For the violent use of the **skēptron**, cf. also Pind. *O.* 7.27-29, Hdt. 6.75.1, Soph. *OT* 811.
- ²⁵ Cf. H. Frisk, *Griechisches etymologisches Wörterbuch* (Heidelberg 1960-1970) II 728-729; P. Chantraine, *Dictionnaire étymologique de la langue grecque* (Paris 1968-1977) IV 1016f.; Benveniste II 30ff.
- ²⁶ It is so used once in the *Iliad*, of the god Hephaestus (18.416).
- ²⁷ Cf. also *Sept.* 428-429, *Pers.* 740.
- ²⁸ The oppressive nature of the **skēptron**, as well as its association with the power of Zeus is explicit at *Il.* 6.158-159:

ὅς ῥ' ἐκ δῆμου ἔλασσεν, ἐπεὶ πολὺ φέρτερος ἦεν,
Ἄργείων· Ζεὺς γάρ οἱ ὑπὸ σκήπτρῳ ἐδάμασσε.

He [Proitos] drove him [Bellerophon] from the Argive people since he was much more powerful: for Zeus had placed them under the sway of his **skēptron**.

- ²⁹ Vernant (above, note 7) I 135.
- ³⁰ It is clear also why the **skēptron** plays so important a role in the swearing of oaths. An oath is in a sense a threat against the oath-taker (in the event that he break the oath), and the

presence of the **skêptron** should call to mind the punitive power of Zeus **Hórkios**. Similarly explicable is the use of the **skêptron** in the decreeing of **dike**. For those making “crooked” judgments, the retribution of the storm-god is severe (*Il.* 16.384-388):

ὥς δ' ὑπὸ λαίλαπι πᾶσα κελαινὴ βέβριθε χθών
 ἤματ' ὀπωρινῷ, ὅτε λαβρότατον χέει ὕδωρ
 Ζεὺς, ὅτε δὴ ῥ' ἄνδρεςσι κοτεσσάμενος χαλεπήνη,
 οἱ βίῃ εἰν ἀγορῇ σκολιάς κρίνωσι θέμιστας,
 ἐκ δὲ δίκην ἐλάσωσι, θεῶν ὅπιν οὐκ ἀλέγοντες.

As on an autumn day the dark earth is oppressed on all sides by a tempest
 when Zeus sends down a driving rain, in angry rage at men who make crooked
 decisions with violence and drive away justice, heedless of the gods' notice.

³¹ Cf. Aescyl. *PV* 761, Soph. *OC* 425, Hdt. 3.142.3, Pind. *P.* 4.152.

³² For the granting of **tímē** to the king under threat of the **skêptron**, cf. also *Il.* 9.155-156:

οἳ κέ ἐ δωτίνῃσι θεὸν ὥς τιμήσουσι
 καὶ οἱ ὑπὸ σκήπτρῳ λιπαράς τελέουσι θέμιστας.

... who will honor him with gifts as they would a god, and under his **skêptron**
 carry out his shining decrees.

³³ I would like to acknowledge a debt of gratitude to Professor Gregory Nagy for his critical reading of this paper, and also to Professor Lowell Edmunds for several helpful bibliographical suggestions.